In Agra, Bairam Khan attempted a last, futile bid to educate the young Padshah as befitted a Timurid king, and brought to the court a Persian immigrant called Mir Abd al-Latif Qazwini to tutor him. Abu'l Fazl approvingly called him a man 'of great eloquence, and of excellent disposition, and so moderate in his religious sentiments, that each party used to revile him for his indifference'. Indeed Mir Abd al-Latif Qazwini enjoyed a certain notoriety for being 'accused in Persia of being a Sunni and in Hindustan of being a Shia'. Akbar studied the *Masnawi* of the Persian poet Maulana Rumi under his tutor and it is believed that a particular section of the poem most appealed to him. This was the section in which God told the Prophet Moses that he had been sent to unite mankind and not to divide it. While it is possible that the tutor may have communicated a love of Persian Sufi poetry to Akbar, the Padshah continued to resist all attempts to formally educate him.

By the next year, 1559, Bairam Khan, fifty-eight years old now, began to act in an increasingly erratic and blustery manner. He baulked at the tighter control over his actions, such as the twice-weekly meetings between the amirs and the Padshah, Akbar's growing independence, and what he would see as increasing interference from the harem and their loyalists. He banished the loyal Maulana Pir Muhammad Shirwani and brought in Haji Muhammad Khan Sistani as his personal wakil. Shaikh Gadai, who had already been appointed sadr,* was now allocated more responsibilities. He also raised some of his patently unqualified servants to positions of eminence. The reaction to all these strategies was immediate and scathing. The nobility began openly to ridicule Bairam Khan and his appointees and a particularly appreciated jibe was one that denigrated the promotion of Haji Muhammad Khan Sistani when it claimed that 'a dog has assumed the status of a sweet seller'. It was further claimed, disastrously for Bairam Khan, that he was opposed to the Chaghatai nobility and was aiming to eliminate them. But the most abhorrent thing he could do, certainly in Akbar's estimation, was to attack the young Padshah's beloved elephant-keepers.

Twice in the course of the year, Bairam Khan had felt himself threatened by rampaging imperial elephants and both times he had had their keepers executed. These elephant-keepers were men that Akbar knew personally and intimately, just as he knew their charges by name. To have these brave and loyal men so summarily executed would have appeared to